

BEM3070

An analysis of 'Talk To Me' and its production company boardwalk
pictures and the applications of technology in low budget International
Horror

[153071]



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1 Introduction

Talk to Me (TTM) is a 2023 horror film directed by Australian brothers and former YouTube stars Danny and Michael Philippou. The film was produced and financed by [Causeway Films](#) and distributed by A24. Blending intense psychological and supernatural horror with social commentary, the film explores themes of grief, trauma, and obsession. It was written, filmed, and produced in Australia.

Causeway Films has established itself as a creative powerhouse in independent Australian horror, renowned for films like *The Babadook* and *The Nightingale*. With TTM, the studio reached a new milestone- its sixth feature became the highest-grossing and most profitable release to date. The film generated \$92.2 million worldwide (\$48.3 million domestically and \$43.6 million internationally) on a modest \$4.25 million production budget (excluding marketing), delivering a 21.6x return on investment. This success not only reinforces Causeway's influence in the genre but also secures a marketable and scalable IP, positioning the company's valuation at around \$300 million. TTM stands out as a disruptive force in an increasingly competitive, highly profitable industry. Its success can be attributed to Causeway Films' scouting and trust of new talent, its innovative marketing approach, and captivating storytelling.

2 The Horror Industry

The film industry is one of the largest and oldest media sectors, with an estimated revenue of \$72.3 billion in 2023. It has become increasingly globalised, with significant growth in China and India (Connock, 2022). Similarly, horror films have expanded rapidly, doubling their box office share over the past decade to exceed 10% in 2023 (Statista, 2024).

2.1 The Economics of Horror

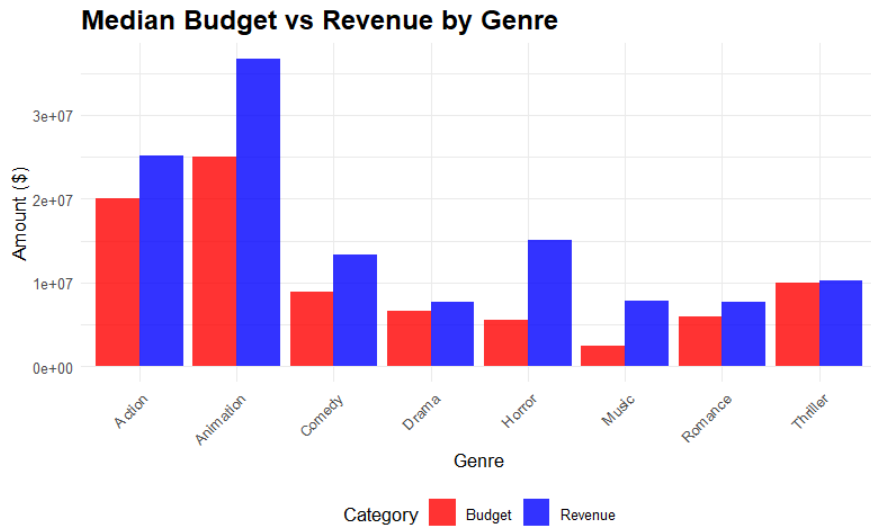
TTM is not alone in demonstrating extraordinary profitability. Horror films consistently achieve exceptional returns on investment- the fundamental metric for producers and investors (Connock, 2022). As shown in Fig.1a, horror delivers the highest revenue relative to production budgets. By contrast, action and thriller require much higher upfront investments while offering only modest revenue gains. This phenomenon, supported by literature (Wallström & Wahlgren, 2018), underscores horror's status as a low-risk, high-reward genre, especially when compared to high-budget blockbusters that often risk calamitous box-office failures (Gunter, 2018).

Studios, therefore, are motivated to invest in projects that minimise risk and maximise returns. Fig.1b illustrates a rising market share for horror films over the years, despite some volatility. The increases may be linked to an industry shift toward high-budget productions and a concurrent decline in mid-budget films. Consequently, many independent directors, who face funding challenges in other genres, are drawn to horror for its greater creative freedom (Turnock, 2019).

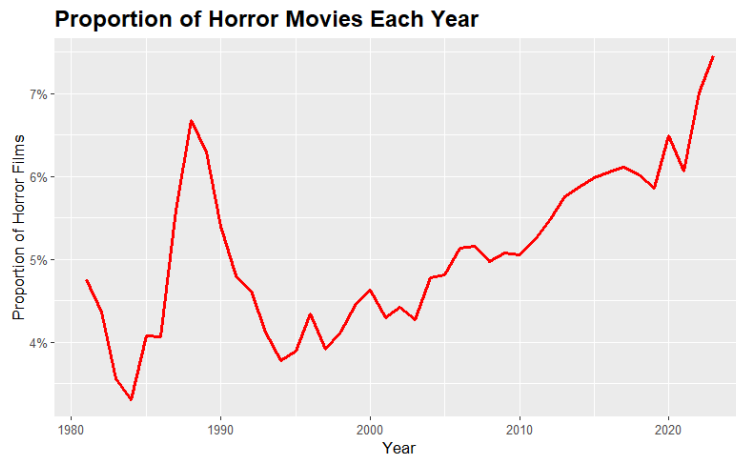
Moreover, horror films benefit from lower production costs: shorter runtimes, lesser-known actors, limited locations, condensed shooting schedules, and minimal use of expensive visual effects. Fig.1c highlights this cost efficiency by showing a high concentration of horror films around the 90-minute mark.

2.2 IP and Sequel Production

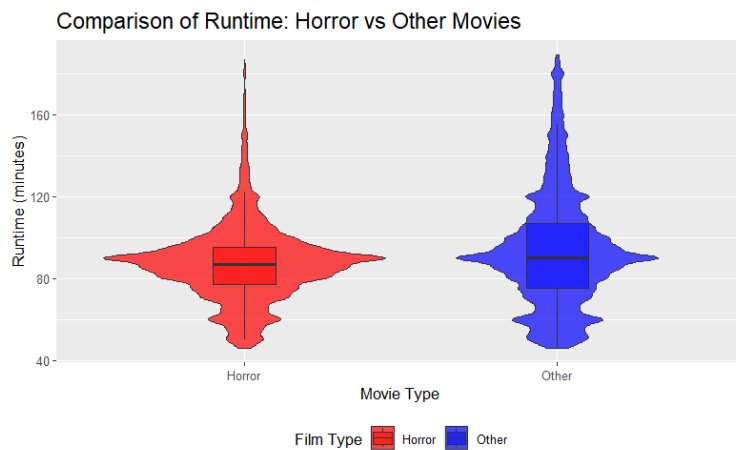
Rather than relying on IP's with expensive rights, horror films are able to quickly and effectively establish a unique identity, after which, there is great potential for sequels, leading to rapid and self sustaining production cycles- dubbed the flywheel effect(Connock, 2022; Strange, n.d.). Cultivating a successful IP can lead to an exponential growth in revenue. A recent example is the 'Terrifier' series- which started with a tiny \$35,000 first entry and \$340,000 return, has with its third instalment



(a)



(b)



(c)

Figure 1: (a) Plot detailing median budget and revenue from different genres from 1980-2024. (b) Plot showing number of Horror films made each year against total films made each year from 1980-2024. (c) Violin plot showing runtime differences in feature films(45 mins or greater) between Horror and other films 1980-2024. Graphs generated in R with data taken from TMDB Movie Database of over 1 million films(Asaniczka, 2025).

sky-rocketed to a \$76 million franchise, with a total production cost of \$2.2 million(Numbers, 2024). Similarly, TTM's huge success prompted the immediate development of a sequel 'Talk 2 Me'- set for release in summer 2025. With an increased budget and filming time the sequel is set to re-exploit the IP from the positive word of mouth over the 2 year gap.

2.3 Target Audience

The horror genre benefits from a highly dependable audience, primarily made up by younger viewers from Gen Z and Millennial demographics, who show strong loyalty by consistently turning out for sequels and franchise instalments. These fans are not only more engaged with the genre overall- watching more films than the average viewer and developing deep attachments to intellectual properties and characters- but they also actively attend cinemas. In fact, about two-thirds of US Gen Z adults reported having watched a horror film in cinemas within the last year, with 30% having seen one in the last month(Statista, 2022). TTM is specifically angled at Gen Z with relatable elements and the youthful energy bought about by the Philippou's image(Truitt, 2023).

2.4 Marketing

Horror themes naturally align with innovative marketing techniques. The Blair Witch Project serves as a prime example, having launched the first truly viral marketing campaign. By combining missing posters with faux police reports, the campaign curated real-life dread and intrigue, prompting audiences to wonder whether the film's events had really occurred (Schreier, 2004). Advancements in technology have further amplified the impact of viral marketing. Modern campaigns utilise buzz marketing to great effect, successfully targeting younger audiences (Gupta, 2021). This targeted approach can cheaply and effectively be steered to capture the attention of younger viewers, ensuring sustained engagement and profitability.

2.5 Monetisation of Horror

Horror thrives on the communal experience and immersive atmosphere provided by cinemas, making it one of the most consistently successful genres at the box office (Tudor, 1997). After theatrical runs, horror films transition to streaming platforms like Netflix and Amazon Prime Video, which have become critical revenue sources for the genre. Streamers typically pay a proportion of a film's

production budget for licensing, making horror titles especially attractive. For instance, Amazon Prime doubled its horror catalogue in 2024, reaching nearly 4,000 hours of content. This exposure aids franchises in gaining new fans but can hinder theatrical releases by saturating the market with readily available horror content (Johansson, 2020). Dedicated platforms like Shudder further cater to horror’s loyal audience by curating collections of classic and indie titles, solidifying streaming as a vital frontier for the genre while maintaining its theatrical appeal.

2.6 Geographical Scope

Proportion of Horror Movies by Continent (2015-2024)

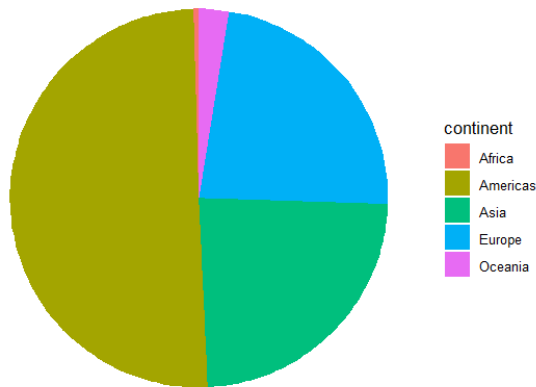


Figure 2: Distribution of Horror Films by Continent, data taken from(Asaniczka, 2025)

Figure 2 shows that horror as an industry is heavily dominated by the Americas with Asia and Europe providing near the rest of the total. Africa and Oceania have a negligible contribution to the overall horror movie industry. However, Australia has carved out a unique place in horror film production, with independent productions that push creative boundaries leaving a lasting impact, particularly in international markets(Ryan, 2008). Unlike the United States, where major studios like Blumhouse and Warner Bros. dominate the horror landscape, Australia’s horror output primarily comes from independent companies, with limited budgets but high creativity. These companies rely on government grants (e.g., Screen Australia) and international co-productions to finance their films. As a result, Australian horror tends to be more experimental, character-driven, and resourceful compared to Hollywood’s franchise-heavy output(John & Joyce, 2020). Despite China’s huge growth, there is currently very little scope for horror owing to censorship of horror concepts.

3 Business Model

This section critically examines Causeway Films’ role in TTM’s production cycle, assessing how each stage led to its success and how the process can be replicated.

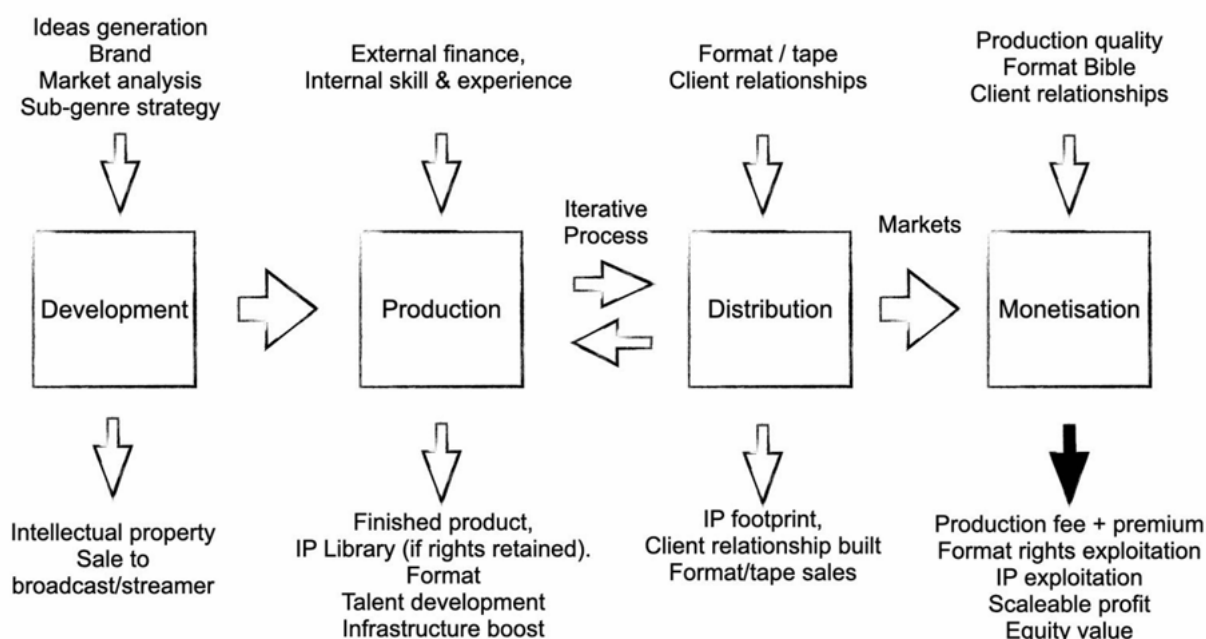


Figure 3: The Value Creation Pipeline detailing the four stages of production from (Connock, 2022)

3.1 Development

As Fig. 1b illustrated horror has become an increasingly crowded genre in recent years, with long-running franchises dominating screens and challenging new projects to differentiate themselves without relying on pre-existing intellectual properties. To stand out, a clear vision or niche that powerfully captures and sustains audience interest across multiple franchise entries is essential.

Causeway recognised this potential in the Philippou brothers' concept- an innovative blend of séances and Gen-Z drug culture. Inspired by a story from Daley Pearson, the film reimaged a genre staple in a way that felt both fresh and culturally relevant.

Beyond the concept itself, Causeway places significant value on the creatives behind a project. The Philippou brothers had built a carefully crafted public persona through their YouTube channel, [RackaRacka](#), amassing 6.87 million subscribers. Known for their bombastic, high-energy short films packed with action and VFX- often created entirely by themselves- the brothers had developed a deep understanding of all stages of production. However, transitioning to feature film-making would require guidance from seasoned producers.

Rather than dismissing them as internet film-makers, Causeway recognised their potential. They had shown themselves to have a great understanding of storytelling, pacing and sustained audience engagement. Causeway provided a hands-on, creatively supportive environment that helped shape both TTM and the directors' evolution into respected feature film-makers (George, 2023).

Samantha Jennings, producer and co-founder of Causeway Films, played a key role in securing the Philippou brothers' trust, convincing them to keep the project in Australia so they could retain creative control and keep costs low. While other studios suggested changes— such as altering the Australian accents for international appeal— Causeway remained committed to preserving the film's authenticity, a decision that ultimately contributed to its distinctive voice and success (Stuckmann, 2023).

As key players in the genre Causeway aided in refining the film's appeal with an understanding of their target audience. A typical horror enthusiast attending their films can be described as follows:

“As a Gen Z horror fan, I’m always searching for films that push the boundaries of fear. Talk to Me stood out for its mix of psychological tension and visceral horror. I prefer films that go beyond jump scares, offering a narrative that lingers long after the credits roll. Realistic performances and practical effects make the experience even more immersive.”

This audience profile reinforced the film's creative direction. The script was intentionally designed to be open-ended, incorporating a rich mythology that encouraged audience speculation and online discussion. Causeway understood that modern horror films are not merely passive experiences but cultural phenomena that inspire analysis, debate, and viral discourse (Gupta, 2021).

As such, TTM was positioned within the subgenre of “elevated horror”, these are films that blend psychological depth, social commentary, and traditional horror elements (Varaksin, 2021). By grounding its supernatural premise in reality, the film amplified its emotional impact. Natural performances, practical effects, and a focus on character-driven storytelling allowed audiences to connect more deeply with the narrative.

This sense of immersion extended to the casting, where the film-makers opted for relatively unknown actors- some without prior feature roles. While this required extensive auditions, it kept costs low and enhanced realism by avoiding the distraction of celebrity recognition. Research suggests that star power does not necessarily boost revenue but does increase production costs (Noam, 2018).

Causeway's support for the Philippou brothers exemplifies its ability to turn bold ideas into commercially and critically successful films (Connock, 2022). By backing directors with strong digital portfolios, Causeway balanced originality with risk, a strategy validated by TTM's success. This approach reflects the growing democratisation of the media industry, with emerging film-makers and smaller film markets, like Australia, poised to benefit from increasing digital interconnectivity.

3.2 Production

TTM was shot on a tight schedule with minimal locations, streamlining production and keeping costs low. The intimate setting allowed for a focused, immersive atmosphere, emphasising tension and character-driven horror rather than relying on elaborate set pieces; this was somewhat of a departure from the Philippou brothers previous body of work and presented a more mature, reflective story. The filming process was highly dynamic, adapting to challenges as they arose. Originally planned as an eight-week shoot, production was abruptly shortened to just five weeks due to the looming threat of the COVID-19 pandemic(Stuckmann, 2023). What did not change was the script and Causeway's continued mentorship of the brothers in their role as directors. Despite the constraints, principal photography was successfully completed, this is likely in part to the background in YouTube which incentivises tight timelines and changing things on the fly.

Causeway was a crucial factor in navigating the many challenges and administrative challenges that emerged. By managing funding, logistics, and industry negotiations, Causeway allowed the Philippou brothers to concentrate on their creative vision, something they had previously not had full leave to do (Stuckmann, 2023).

Financing the film required multiple investment sources, including a private firm and the countries funding body Screen Australia (Lee, 2023). Casting first-time actor Sophie Wilde as Mia resulted in a loss of funding, leading the Philippous to reinvest their own fees, with Causeway Films following suit. This risky decision ultimately paid off, increasing the film's revenue and strengthening Causeway's relationship with the directors. With their proven success, future projects are likely to secure funding more easily.

To maintain a low budget without sacrificing impact, TTM leaned heavily on practical effects, particularly in its depiction of supernatural entities. Prosthetics and physical effects were extensively used to create the film's eerie and unsettling demons, adding a sense of realism that CGI often struggles to replicate (Seo & Park, 2020). This practical approach not only helped control costs but also contributed to the film's distinctive visual style, making it stand out in a genre often dominated by digital effects.

TTM became a valuable asset for Causeway— a marketable film with strong commercial appeal and sequel potential. More importantly, it established a promising new IP, reinforcing the studio's reputation for fostering breakout horror projects. The film's efficient production, small crew, and reliance on practical effects made it an attractive prospect for investors, demonstrating the viability

of Causeway's film-maker-friendly approach.

By guiding the Philippou brothers through their directorial debut, Causeway positioned them for future success. This trust led to their next project, *Bring Her Back*, set for release in 2025, and the planned sequel *Talk 2 Me*. This approach created a flywheel effect—by cultivating strong creative partnerships, Causeway could continuously leverage proven talent for new films, aligning with its strategy of organic growth.

3.3 Distribution

TTM made an immediate impact, premiering at the Sundance Film Festival in January 2023 and igniting a bidding war that resulted in A24 acquiring the North American distribution rights for a high seven-figure sum (Couch, 2023). The partnership between Causeway Films and A24 was symbiotic, as both companies share a commitment to innovative storytelling on modest budgets. Causeway gained access to A24's marketing expertise and dedicated fanbase, while A24 capitalised on the film's commercial potential and future franchise development. Following Sundance, TTM received widespread recognition, winning Best Horror Film at the Saturn Awards and earning eight AACTA honors, including Best Actor, Best Director, and Best Film. While strong production values do not guarantee success, they positioned Causeway for viral recognition.

Beyond the strong word of mouth, the Philippou brothers leveraged their influencer status to play a key role in marketing, utilising their YouTube platform to connect with fans through emotionally resonant behind-the-scenes content. They also engaged audiences at premieres with stunts and interviews, expanding the film's visibility in digital communities. Experiential marketing further enhanced the campaign, with "scare boxes" creating viral horror moments and a 'Fortnite Deadpines' collaboration targeting Gen Z gamers— a demographic with significant overlap in horror audiences (Sidorenko-Bautista & Castillo-Abdul, 2025).

The distribution deal positioned TTM as a cultural phenomenon at no cost to Causeway. Riding the \$10 million U.S. opening weekend (TheNumbers, 2024) Causeway green-lit the sequel *Talk 2 Me*. Its \$90 million box office run was followed by a strategic move into digital sales at \$20 per purchase. This positioning avoided physical media releases to cater to Gen Z's preferences while minimising costs. This was followed by a digital release onto Netflix for December of that year.

Once the film was acquired by A24, Causeway's influence on the film's performance was negligible. The collaboration ensured TTM's success, from securing Sundance buzz to maximising its theatrical

and digital rollout. This partnership exemplifies how effective distribution, and innovative marketing can transform an indie horror film into a global hit. Additionally by having creatives with existing passionate fans they were able to gain tremendous amount of free exposure, looking to new creatives with similar backgrounds for future projects could further capitalise on this network effect.

3.4 Monetisation

It is clear that the Philippou's and Causeway had crafted something special with TTM- both commercially and critically. A horror with broad appeal that has bold interesting ideas, authenticity and captivating performances.

TTM's strong production design and imagery served as its "format bible," throughout marketing and distribution. The embalmed hand central to the plot, curated a memorable visual identity that resonated with audiences and marketing campaigns. This cohesive aesthetic not only enhanced audience engagement but also laid the groundwork for future franchise expansions by establishing a clear and repeatable visual language- the hand is used in the A24 logo for instance and large scale ones are present at many of the premiers.

TTM's \$4.5 million production budget was likely recouped immediately through A24's high seven-figure acquisition deal. This upfront payment not only mitigated financial risk but also provided Causeway Films with the resources to focus on future projects. Causeways partnership with A24 and other global distributors was strengthened throughout the distribution phase. TTM was A24's most profitable horror film.

TTM demonstrates highly scalable profit through its franchise model. Horror films often maintain fan loyalty over decades, providing a wealth of opportunities. Nurturing a fanbase is essential for this as sustained quality and innovation within the franchise can see decades of revenue.

Take the Consumer lifetime value equation Connock, [2022](#)

$$CLV_{\infty} = \frac{g}{1 + d - r} - CAC \quad (1)$$

Given the \$90 million box office haul, it's estimated that the film attracted 9 million fans to theatres. Considering its extensive streaming presence since then, the film likely has an even larger fan base. With a quick turnaround—thanks to the film's short production cycle—it's expected that sequels will continue to be released every two and a half years. Assuming a ticket price of \$10, a high retention

rate(r) of 0.8 due to the film's strong appeal, a 0.15 discount rate(d) as an independent studio, and a low customer acquisition cost (CAC) driven by heavy reliance on earned media, the Customer Lifetime Value (CLV) is estimated to be as high as \$30, without factoring in new monetisation strategies.

With a catalogue of previous horror films with their unique style, it took until TTM for Causeways to break into the mainstream and have a project worthy of heavy investment into a sequel. Now is the perfect time to expand the opportunities for the Philippou brothers by providing them with additional projects that build on the success of TTM. The film exemplifies how independent films can achieve scalable profits by combining efficient production processes with innovative distribution and marketing strategies. By leveraging A24's expertise and focusing on IP exploitation and franchise development, Causeway Films maximised both short-term revenue and long-term growth potential. Future projects can build on this model by expanding merchandising opportunities, exploring streaming partnerships, but above all maintaining high-quality storytelling, that will sustain audience loyalty over decades. With a solid foundation, Causeway is well-positioned to continue creating successful, profitable franchises that appeal to a broad, engaged audience.

4 Impact of technology

However, despite the recent success of TTM the film industry is in a period of great change. Beyond the well-trodden existential risks that AI presents—a rich source of inspiration for horror writers, as seen in *M3GAN*, *The Terminator*, and *Companion*—AI also offers a range of transformative tools for film producers.

4.1 Development Aids

Predicting box office success remains a well trodden yet complex challenge. Various methods, have been applied to assess potential movie performance (Sawhney & Eliashberg, 1996; Sharda & Delen, 2006). Although they have demonstrated improvements over earlier models, they continue to struggle in capturing the multifaceted and dynamic elements of society that influence the film industry (Quader et al., 2017). The industry's reliance on incalculable factors- such as creativity, cultural trends, and audience psychology- resists precise mathematical modelling, complicating efforts to predict commercial success. Therefore low budget, risk-free projects will continue to be essential for

smaller scale studios.

AI-driven VFX, however, could enable independent studios to create larger-scale productions, expanding horror's scope and allowing smaller companies to compete in the more expensive action and adventure genres. If Causeway stays committed to character-driven narratives, these tools could enhance their storytelling without compromising originality.

As AI becomes more accessible, new film-makers—like the Philippou brothers—will emerge. Causeway could identify and nurture such talent using AI-driven scouting, much as they did with TTM. Additionally incorporating AI tools could streamline certain aspects of the creative process without compromising originality. This includes market analysis- using advanced social media metrics and script refinement with programs such as Jasper AI.

Causeway must remain vigilant about AI-generated content. Feeding genre-defining scripts into large language models (LLMs) risks flooding the market with cheap imitations, diluting originality. While some AI-driven projects may have artistic merit, many will be mass-produced. To stand out, Causeway must safeguard intellectual property, prioritize human-driven storytelling, and position its films as high-quality features.

4.2 Post-Production

Where AI does offer great promise is in the streamlining of post-production, by providing editing benefits this will greatly reduce the post production timeline(Naji, 2024). In the case of TTM filming wrapped in April of 2023, but post production was not complete until over 3 Months later. For larger projects this is amplified with post production often spanning up to a year after filming has wrapped. Tools like Edit Cloud are already helping to cut down on these delays by enabling remote collaboration and automating certain aspects of the workflow. For small companies like Causeway this is particularly useful, allowing them to focus their efforts on purely creative endeavours- much like they allowed the Philippou's to do.

Additionally, advanced AI dubbing features allow films to be shown in more territories without the need to hire voice actors. By synthesising the original actor's voice, AI can generate dialogue in multiple languages while maintaining emotional tone and lip-sync accuracy. This approach not only reduces costs but also provides a more natural viewing experience, as it preserves the original actor's voice for audiences worldwide. In emotionally resonant films like Causeway's this authenticity ties closely to their objectives and would strongly position them to tackle growing markets like india .

4.3 Dynamic Content

AI offers the possibility for content that dynamically adapts depending upon the viewers response. Owing to its visceral and engaging nature, no genre is set to benefit from this greater than horror. The success of Black Mirror: Bandersnatch highlights the growing audience interest in interactive horror narratives. Post the successful implementation of TTM in Fortnite, Causeway could explore similar ventures through branching storylines, AI-driven adaptive horror, or VR/AR experiences. These experiences could respond to viewer inputs and dynamically learn from users in order to amplify select fears. Content like this would greatly increase the sustained engagement with media projects- similar to games, as currently horror films are typically one and done success. When paired with Causeways experience in realistic and powerful psychological fear they could partner with similar Australian games companies like x and form a composite to break into the new type of media.

5 Conclusion

This essay has explored the key factors behind TTM's success: a swiftly executed, low-budget production that emphasised practical effects, a carefully curated talent pool both in front of and behind the camera, and a captivating story that ignited the audience's imagination and sparked demand for more content rooted in its unique mythology. Additionally, A24's bold, marketing strategies and credibility played a critical role in reaching a far wider audience than previous projects.

Looking ahead, this framework positions Causeway to replicate such success by fully supporting the creative process. By maintaining modest budgets, film-makers are encouraged to be resourceful, reducing the financial risk of high-budget flops while maximising the potential for high profit margins.

Moreover, technological advancements are set to further revolutionise the industry by streamlining project planning, post-production, and even complex visual effects. With new media channels and a sustained focus on character driven narratives Causeway can set itself apart as a disruptor and innovator in the expanding industry.

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